



DELIGHTFUL AT NIGHT
A view of the lobby and pool at the Cheetahgarh Resort

it's a smorgasbord of cattle, sheep, goats, and dogs. Jawai's leopards prey on these at will, and scavenge cattle corpses left in the scrub. In some places that would get a leopard killed—goats and sheep are about Rs 5,000 a pop, cattle double that—but the villagers are happy to give up a few livestock to what they consider a quasi-divine being.

No Jia this evening, but dinner is quasi-divine. Bhawani zooms up another massive rock in the dark and deposits me on the wide flat top. There's nothing here but the stars, the wind, a candlelit table, and full bar service. It's what the resort calls Signature Dining—a wilderness location with luxury dining. A private chef and butler spin out a series of barbecued delights while I chat with Mr Bakshi and sip Godawan single malt named after Rajasthan's endangered state bird, the great Indian bustard. The highlight of eight plates is a pile of melt-in-the-mouth mutton. The table is gorgeous, the breeze is cool, the stars twinkle. This is how dining should be.

Speaking of stars, do not miss the resort telescope in the clear desert sky. I can't believe I'm actually looking at Saturn, 1.3 billion kilometres away—those rings, and its moon Titan!—and Jupiter, 643 million kilometres away—those stripes! There's the star Vega, 25 light years away, and Procyon 11.4 light years away. I have goosebumps.

At the crack of dawn, we visit a Rabari family before the men take their herds off for the day. The landscape around Kotar Bagal village is jewelled in *anwal* flowers. In a hut made of straightened dhauk branches and roofed with dried *palash* leaves and a tarp, a woman is making rotis for lunch, and she boils up some delicious sweet tea for us. We are introduced to Kishore the camel and Sheru the dog. I ask one man about his tattoos, and his face explodes into gleeful wrinkles. "I used to be very beautiful," he says conspiratorially, "This was to avoid the evil eye." He's still beautiful, in his blood-red turban, white garments, and jewellery. The Rabaris' matriarchal, semi-nomadic herder culture is fascinating, but it's a hard way of life, one the children don't want, and I wonder how long it will last.

It's too hot to walk once the sun is up, so after breakfast I visit the gym. The rooms have power backup against frequent power cuts, and I like to think they will soon also put the gym machines on a UPS.

In a sudden evening downpour, we drive to Jagtala, a rocky hill that Neelam likes. Bhawani parks us up away from a crowd of jeeps, on a rise facing the hill. Ninety minutes have passed when a magnificent leopard shimmers into view. He's a mass of roiling muscles just slightly more golden than the rock. It's Chhote Kaan, Neelam's cub and occasional beau, the area's dominant male. He stands and looks around, yawns, strolls slowly up the rock face, and disappears over the crest as gold explodes across the sky. Those couple of minutes are more than worth the wait. We visit the scenic Jawai dam under a blood-red sunset before heading home.

Dinner is at the resort's Jawai Under the Sky—an al fresco treat of fresh pizza from a wood-fired oven, and tasty barbecued meats.

I cap my trip with a morning nature walk. Varghese Jain can correctly identify what to me looks like a smudge against a jumble dozens of yards away. I need his monoscope at Rotela Lake to watch sunbirds, kingfishers, egrets, bee-eaters, white-browed wagtails, bulbuls, black-headed ibis, ashy-crowned sparrow lark, the beautiful grey Eurasian collared dove, and jezebel and tiger butterflies. Even one of the crocodiles briefly heaves itself into view. It's not just leopards, you know.

I leave already wanting to come back to Jawai and Cheetahgarh, where the sky is epic, the rooms are comfy, the food is good, the rocks are hot, the cats are cool, and the chances of seeing one are, I concede, 95-100 per cent.

Go. You won't regret it. ■